

CRIATIVO GLOBAL NEWSLETTER



The Hidden Ingredient of Great Schools: Belonging, Culture, and Connection

The **August 2026** edition explores the growing focus on **school culture and student wellbeing**, highlighting recent developments across **India and the UAE** alongside emerging research on belonging. From mental-health support and student voice to stronger school relationships, the evidence points to a simple idea: students are more likely to engage, persist and succeed when they feel **seen, supported and connected** to their learning community.

India: Bringing Mental Health Support Closer to Students

Karnataka is set to **appoint mental health resource persons across its block resource centres**, who will support students with counselling, stress, exam pressure and peer relationships. Teachers will also receive training to identify emotional and behavioural concerns earlier.



India: Mental Wellbeing Moves Higher on the Education Agenda

India's Ministry of Education is developing a **National Mental Health and Well-Being Policy for Schools**. The policy aims to strengthen mental wellbeing across the wider school ecosystem, including students, teachers and school communities.



DESIGNING SCHOOLS WHERE STUDENTS FEEL SEEN



Sikkim: Turning Wellbeing Into an Interactive School Experience

Sikkim's **AYURVIDYA School Health Programme** brought students together for discussions on stress, mindfulness, breathing exercises and gratitude. By encouraging students to **participate, reflect and ask questions**, the programme makes wellbeing an active part of school culture.

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Dubai: Tackling Behaviour Through Culture, Dialogue and Support

A new Dubai initiative is addressing bullying, vaping, gaming addiction and declining interest in learning through **awareness, workshops and student dialogue**. The programme reflects a wider focus on creating healthier environments where students feel supported and connected.

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Punjab: Training Teachers to Recognise Mental Health Concerns

Punjab is **training more than 21,850 teachers across 12 districts** to recognise early signs of mental health difficulties and substance abuse among students. The initiative highlights the growing role teachers can play in **early identification and support**, alongside their academic responsibilities.

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FROM CONNECTION TO CONFIDENCE: THE CASE FOR BELONGING



India: A National Focus on Student Wellbeing

In June, India's National Task Force on student mental health reported that it had conducted field visits to **30 higher education institutions across 10 states**, alongside 25 stakeholder consultations. Its work is examining how education systems can create more inclusive, supportive environments and strengthen preventive mental-health measures.

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What the Research Says: Belonging Can Influence How Students Learn

Recent research continues to connect **student-teacher relationships, school climate and belonging** with student wellbeing and engagement. A June systematic review found that whole-school approaches can play an important role in supporting mental health, while [OECD research](#) links stronger school belonging and positive student-teacher relationships with better attendance.

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Closing Note

Great school culture is rarely created through one programme or policy. It is built through everyday interactions: **a teacher who knows a student's name, a classroom where students feel safe to speak, and a school that listens**. For education leaders, belonging should be treated not as an additional wellbeing initiative, but as part of the **infrastructure of learning itself**. When students feel they belong, they are more likely to participate, connect and keep going.